How is social media influencing changing branding from a transactional process into an entrepreneurial practice

Teresa Burrell

George Mason University

BAS 490 DL1: Introduction to Research Methods

Professor Andrea Calvin

May 3rd, 2026

Abstract

Social media and user-generated content platforms have created entire industries for anyone who is interested enough to press the “post” button. Personal social media platforms have grown into entire media channels with the goal of brand communication. This pipeline has seen social media influencers grow into entrepreneurs. The structure of this research entails two guiding frameworks from the literature review, Cheng, Regt, & Young’s Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model (2024) and Fink’s Influencer Branding Performance Triangle (2021) to create an evidence-based guide from the perspective of Alex Cooper’s career trajectory. This case study uses mixed methods; both qualitative and quantitative, data pulled from Spotify Web API, YouTube Data API v3, and Social Blade. Data is pulled from 2019 to 2026 and processed through R, the statistical computing and graphics software. The data solidified industry standards that have been studied using Alex Cooper’s career and business strategy, offering a guide to marketers, influencers, researchers, and strategists for successful identity-based brand management.

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Introduction

The rise of social media has shaken the foundations of what marketing and branding have become. Traditional advertising used to be billboards, repetitive slogans, and celebrity cameos. Digital platforms created a new framework where everyday users commercialized relatability and monetized their personal lives (Hofstetter and Gollnhofer 2024). By creating overnight online personalities**,** the need arose to balance authentic, relatable people and strategic marketing assets. Brands relied on the grass-roots aspect of social media influencers to bridge the gap between brands and consumers.

Scholars documented the rapid growth of social media marketing as well as the expansion of scope in the advertising industry. For instance, Fink (2021) found that while digital ad expenditures increased by 29 percent in 2018, consumers were more likely to trust influencers deemed "friend-akin" compared to traditional advertising channels. Similarly, Doyle et al. (2022) demonstrated how Major League Soccer (MLS) players used already established notoriety to catalyze personal online branding. From a conceptual perspective, psychological elements such as affinity, trust, and loyalty persuaded consumer purchase habits in social media influencer contexts (Rajput and Gandhi 2024**).** Hudders, De Jans, & De Veirman (2020) warned that too much commercialization risked a non-authentic perception by social media audiences while Cheng et al. (2024) labeled influencers as regular users who have capitalized off influence to jumpstart public entrepreneurship careers. This stressed the need to consider personal online branding as a new medium for marketing and advertising. The dynamic relationship between consumers, influencers, and brands called for the connection between practical online marketing frameworks and entrepreneurial brand building.

Statement of Purpose

The study seeks to explain the value of online personal brand building, investigating the entrepreneurial trajectory of Alex Cooper, and subsequently fill the research gap by providing an evidence-based guide to entrepreneurial brand building. It is built upon the work of Fink (2021) and Cheng, Regt, & Young (2024) in empirically visualizing how brand marketing, through influencing, shifts the traditional process into an entrepreneurial process. This project is formally guided by the following research question: How is social media influencing changing branding from a transactional process into an entrepreneurial practice?

Literature Review

The literature review exposed a research gap between social media, content creation, and marketing. This can best be encapsulated across four interconnected principles: content creation, branding, marketing, and influencing.

Figure 1. *Existing Frameworks in Social Media Marketing Research*



Note. (Source: own illustration based on four interconnected principles)

Drivers of User Engagement (Content Creation)

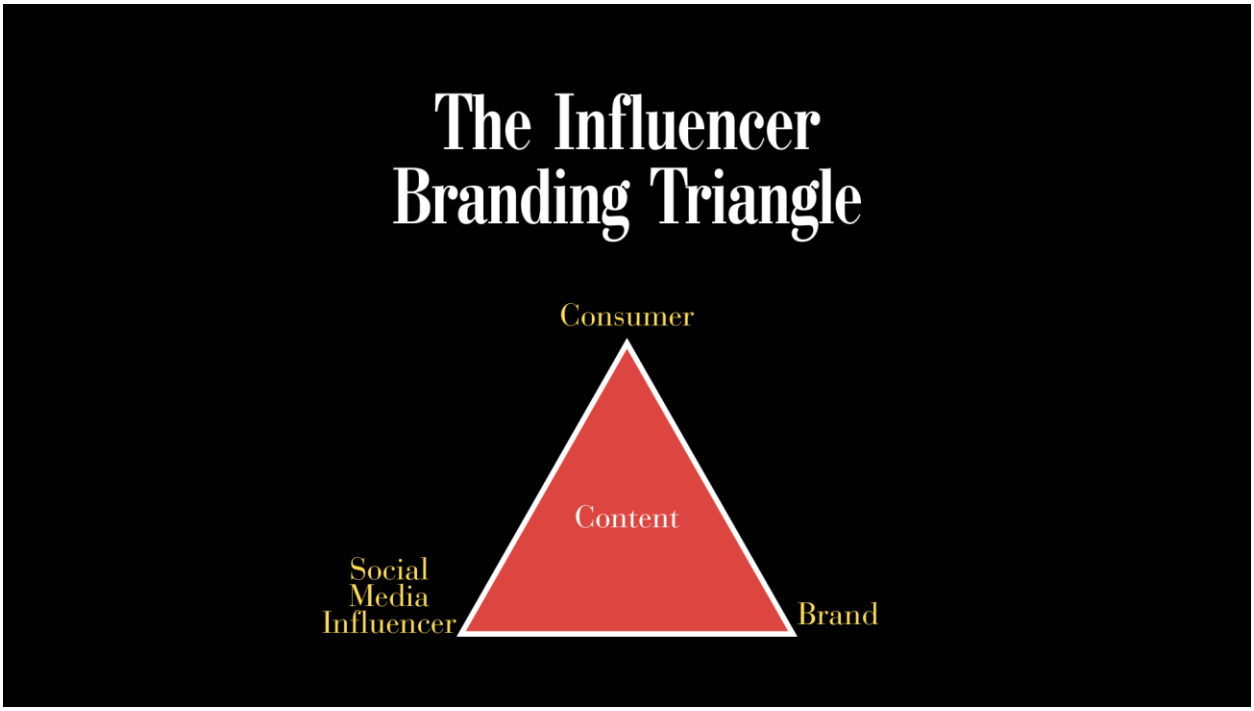
Fink (2021) analyzed the landscape of digital advertising expenditures in German markets between 2018 and 2020 to have increased 13.9 percent nationally, and 29 percent globally. Fink mentions the most pressing issue within advertising during this time was the "trust gap". Stating that while "trust in digital media channels" were "comparably low", consumers most trust product recommendations of their friends, family "and those of social media influencer (SMIs) who represent 'friend-akin' individuals in users' daily lives (p. 141). Fink's focus in this study was to legitimize the content that connects brand, consumer, and social media influencers, stating that SMI's are incorporated in the process of brand management "in order to reach pre-defined brand outcomes" (Fink, 2021). This recognized the criteria for what made SMI's reliable sources for consumers and offering guidelines on how to create a successful influencer branding campaign.

The user generated content (UGC) of six different brands in three categories were collected between 2018 and 2020. The categories were diapers, cosmetics and beauty, and household appliances. Within the six categories, the six brands were Pampers, Lillydoo, Maybelline, Artdeco, Nescafe Dolce Gusto, and Senseo. Fink (2021) tracked the UGC posted around these brands within the same period guided the comparative approach to assess which factors most effectively drive engagement. Findings included influencer characteristics, brand placement, quality of content, and authenticity to be major factors in bringing in user engagement. Furthermore, Fink originally suggested that physical attractiveness was a leading factor in enabling engagement, but instead found that informative content, high credibility, and strong brand fit increased trustworthiness to an audience. Specific brand related information would translate as an "expertise-push" given the degree of fit-construct (also known as match-up

hypothesis). Fit-construct defined by Sturm (2011, as cited in Fink, 2021) as consumers positively perceive brands and SMI's branded content only if "highly relevant characteristics of the [SMI] are consistent with highly relevant attributes of the brand". Subsequently, any indication of inauthenticity would suggest projecting "extrinsic motivations" (p. 71).

This study emphasized the role of SMI's in the social media marketing industry as vessels brands could use to bridge the gap between brand campaigns and consumers, solidifying influencer marketing as an effective tactic towards humanizing advertising. Social media influencers, content, and brand are most effective when product placement is obvious; ad disclosure is transparent, and that the influencer is perceived to have a high fit-construct with the brand. Fink culminated her work with the Influencer Branding Performance Triangle, where consumer, brand, and social media influencers come together to define influencer branding.

Figure 2. *The Influencer Branding Triangle*



Note. (Source: Own illustration adapted from Sinnig (2019) via Fink (2021))

Athlete Branding (Branding)

Doyle et al. (2022) investigated the factors that drive user engagement with Major League Soccer (MLS) players on social media. 1,727 Instagram posts made by 289 male professional athletes were monitored over a one-month observation period on public profiles to determine the relationship between content and engagement. This study places athletes in two categories: athletes who are celebrities and athletes who are brands. Findings concluded that user engagement (likes and/or comments) ranged depending on the type of content posted. Increased user engagement was found on posts that included athlete's teammates and superior quality photos. Decreased user engagement was found in posts where the captions included hashtags. Doyle et al. (2022) concluded that athletes who already possess influence by way of their careers strategically leverage social media to increase credibility and created a brand for themselves. This displays another side of branding where the influencer already has celebrity and amplifies it to extend their image using social media as the medium. (Outline guided by Open AI, 2025).

Influencers and Purchasing Intention (Marketing)

Rajput and Gandhi (2024) described the rise of influencer marketing as a core component of brand strategy and asked how the effect of homophily, social presence, and physical attractiveness of influencers affect consumers affinity and how trust and loyalty mediate the relationships between influencer attributes, affinity, and purchase intentions.

This study was conducted by recruiting participants to answer a survey. Researchers targeted users on Google Invite, WhatsApp, Instagram, and Facebook. Eligible participants were required to have followed influencers in the beauty and fashion industries and have made a purchase within the past six months because of influencer marketing. The final breakdown of valid responses included 408 total, 49.5% female and 50.5% male participants. Of the total valid

responses, 72.6% were under the age of thirty-five**.** Findings highlighted that trust, loyalty, affinity, and homophily were central to understanding the relationship between consumer behavior and purchasing choices. Influencers who are physically attractive and have built trust between themselves and followers have a higher chance of informing their purchasing decisions. The user feels the influencer is a thought leader that has the interest of their audience in mind. Rajput and Gandhi concluded that credibility and relatability of influencer-built affinity within their followers even beyond their first impression. This evolving affinity is what led to a strong social presence of the influencer that then in turn increased the purchasing decisions of the follower through a digitally curated sense of trust.

Rajput and Ghandi encouraged marketers to decenter robust marketing campaigns and to focus on the relationship between influencers and consumers. Affinity can be used as a measurement system that indicates the credibility and relatability of an influencer to the consumer. The connection between a strong social media presence and purchase intention should be at the forefront of any brand management strategy. Furthermore, this enhances the work of Fink's Influencer Branding Performance Triangle (2021) by highlighting the consumer, brand, and SMI as touch points of influencer branding.

Commercialization of Influencers (Influencing)

Hudders et al. **(**2020) conducted a literature review that resulted in a conceptual framework to answer how commercialization affects authenticity and effectiveness between influencer and audience. This study followed three concepts: 1) the value perception of social media influencers (SMI's) and what plays a role in this judgement 2) the efficacy of sponsored influencer endorsements and 3) the formation of brand evaluation by sponsored posts. Hudders et al. **(**2020) focused on the perception of the influencer from the audiences' perspective, offering a

different side of data that marketers can use when building influencer brand strategy, specifically for creators with a high following. They suggested that audiences respond well to influencers that created strong parasocial dynamics between them and their followers, promoted content within their expertise, and formatted content as storytelling. These findings warned against the over commercialization of well-established influencers, as it could threaten their perceived "authenticity and honesty" by prioritizing a brand's notoriety over their audience.

This literature review was one of the earliest collections of work documenting the "first wave of influencing". The three streams of value perception aid in solidifying influencers as essential marketing assets within the industry. This work is essential is understanding how influencing has evolved throughout the last decade and how it can inform the industry in a digital age that is rapidly growing.

Influencer-Entrepreneurship Pipeline

Cheng, Regt, & Young (2024) built upon the social capital theory (Adler et al. 2002) and entrepreneurship value creation theory (Mishra et al. 2015) proposing a stage model of progression that leverages online brand building towards personal entrepreneurial goals. The social capital theory can be defined as "the good will that is engendered by the fabric of social relations and that can be mobilized to facilitate action" (Adler et al. 2002). The entrepreneurship value creation theory "examines the interiors of the entrepreneurial process using a two-stage value creation and appropriation framework" (Mishra et al. 2014). This two-stage framework starts with venture formulation and is followed by entrepreneurial competence. Cheng et al.'s model intended to "capture how and why consumers respond differently to influencers at different stages of their career journey" and to demonstrate how they "transform across various stages of entrepreneurial progression and facilitate strategic marketing engagement" (Cheng et

al., 2024). This framework created the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model that includes five stages of value drivers that break down how influencers constructed a personal brand into a sustainable online enterprise. The value drivers are; the influence potential stage, the influence formulation stage, the influence competence stage, the influence monetization stage, and the influence reward stage. The stages are measured using a scale; starting with potential, nascent, new, growing, and established. This scale offers influencers a tool to measure progression as they grow their platform, user engagement, and monetization at each stage.

This study provides a view of influencer career trajectory and extends past assumption that influencers are just marketing assets; delineating the process through consumer, social media users, content creators, creative collaborators, and owners of nascent brands. By harnessing their attentional capital and persuasive power, they can affect audience decision-making; a tool essential for growing human brands. Personal branding is a method for entrepreneurs to develop an online image beyond the constraints of traditional brand endorsing. In the congruence of human brands and personal branding, this blend "links [influencer's] personal worth to market value" (Cheng et al., 2024). The Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model is not only a guide on digital entrepreneurship through visualizing "transformations in their identities, brand relationships, and consumer perceptions (Cheng et al., 2024)**,** but it also encourages influencers to use their digital branding experience as a catalyst towards personal entrepreneurial endeavors. The current state of digital marketing allows anyone to monetize user generated content, and the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model suggests that audiences are receptive of human brands that facilitate a digital environment to develop their social capital and collaborate with stakeholders to evolve through each stage.

Conclusion

The literature collectively illustrated that social media has redefined marketing and branding by centering authenticity, trust, and relational engagement as the primary drivers of influence. Empirical studies (Fink, 2021; Doyle et al., 2022; Rajput & Gandhi, 2024) revealed that consumer behavior was increasingly shaped by emotional connection, perceived similarity, and loyalty rather than traditional advertising techniques. Conceptual contributions (Hudders et al., 2020; Cheng et al., 2024) extended this understanding, emphasizing both the risks of over-commercialization and the evolution of influencers into entrepreneurial brand builders.

As digital users began to see the value in the digitization of brand marketing, the lines between social media and marketing blurred. It is clear in the relationship-driven dynamic of social media marketing made traditional marketing seem one dimensional. Brand marketing became less tangible and more a perception of proximity between the audience and influencer. This literature review exposed a knowledge gap within the industry that fails to connect empirical and conceptual data. The research that follows will provide an evidence-based guide that uses empirical and conceptual knowledge as a tool for effective brand management.

Methodology

Study Design

This project consisted of two phases 1) a case study of Alex Cooper's career trajectory from YouTube creator to media mogul that provided the scaffold for 2) a Literature Analysis that focused on four principles for social media influencer marketing: content creation, branding, marketing, and influencing. The overall research indicated a reoccurring theme within Cooper's

career trajectory based on the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model as guided by Cheng, Regt, & Young (2024), and Fink's Influencer Branding Performance Triangle (2021).

This study design included both qualitative and quantitative research. Qualitative data included articles, press reports, and interviews. Quantitative data included social media data points from Instagram, Spotify, and YouTube, and reports on the growth of Cooper's multiple businesses. This became a descriptive research design that analyzed data and content without manipulating variables. The goal of this case study was to understand and document the characteristics and variables needed to successfully complete the Influencer-Entrepreneurship pipeline as guided by Cheng et al. (2024) as an in-depth phenomenon.

Procedure

Measures and Key Concepts: The online presence of Alex Cooper was analyzed between the period of May 2018 to March 2026. The case study analyzed how Cooper became a media mogul around the time of this study, referencing the industries Cooper has business ventures in. The case study is organized using the five stages of the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model: influencer potential, influencer formulation, influencer competence, influencer monetization, influencer reward (Cheng et al). The literature analysis was built from this case study using the four principles (content creation, branding, marketing, and influencing), as well as the themes.

Data Collection: Qualitative data was collected from published interviews articles, and press reports to analyze Cooper's business acumen. This portion relied on personal interviews Cooper has participated in with Vogue, Marie Claire, Forbes, and more. Qualitative data was gathered on the branding strategy implemented through both Cooper's professional and personal

online platforms, including content and brand partnerships. Quantitative data was video release cadence, YouTube reach, and audience engagement metrics from the Call Her Daddy (CHD) channels on YouTube and Spotify. This data was pulled using the respective platforms application programming interface (API), specifically Spotify Web API and YouTube Data API v3. The second batch of metrics pulled was net followers gained on Alex Cooper's personal Instagram, the CHD Instagram, and finally, the Unwell Network Instagram. This data was pulled using the free version of Social Blade as a third-party data source. Furthermore, relevant reports on the growth of Cooper's multiple businesses, Unwell Network, Unwell Hydration, and Unwell Creative Agency, were collected to triangulate the data with the Influencer-Entrepreneurship model and other business milestones.

Data Processing and Storage: Data from social media platforms and dates from press reports, interviews, etc. was gathered and stored on Google Sheets. Data was processed using R.

Data Analysis: Data was collected, organized, and analyzed using NVivo. Using content from interviews and social media data to identify patterns and insights that coincide with the Influencer-Entrepreneur Model and Influencer Branding Performance Triangle. The Four Principles of Social Media Influencer Marketing was used concurrently with findings from the literature analysis to identify themes in Cooper's career trajectory. Engagement metrics were analyzed to show trends over time and comparatively analyze how Cooper's career progression correlates with audience interaction. Quantitative and qualitative data was used to support a social media influencer marketing guide. Additionally, data gaps found will suggest future research questions to students, marketers, and influencers.

Data Visualization: Visual representation of the data can be organized by a timeline of Cooper's career trajectory, starting in 2018. The timeline can be followed by the metrics

successfully achieved per the Influencer-Entrepreneur Model (IE) and influencer branding performance triangle. An infographic representing the qualitative and quantitative data is represented as a pyramid.

Limitations: CHD content was often reposted on both platforms for a multitude of reasons; filming breaks and shorter clips of full-length podcasts reposted as YouTube Shorts as a part of digital strategy. Because of this, a deduplication process was done in R to keep the highest-viewed version retained per unique title. A systematic keyword search for re-uploads was also done and returned zero matches. However, upon a manual check, reuploads were only labeled as "throwbacks" in the thumbnails of the video. The YouTube API metadata could not identify which videos were "throwbacks", so the highest-viewed version of each video podcast was kept. In June 2021, CHD signed an exclusive $60 million deal with Spotify. This accounts for the YouTube data gap between 2021-2023 consistent with the exclusivity agreement, pulling all video podcasts from YouTube and only onto Spotify. The third-party data source, Social Blade, was inconsistent in data tracking engagement metrics on Cooper's personal account. Further research found that commenting had been turned off for the month, affecting the tracking data offered by the platform. Finally, Social Blade's free version only allowed net subscriber/follower change not gross vs lost.

Results

Spotify Release Cadence

560 episodes of Cooper's podcast Call Her Daddy (CHD) from October 2018 to March 2026 via Spotify Web API. The average days between the release of podcast video episodes decreased over time. The consistency in posting shifted from seven days within the influence potential/influencer formulation stage of the podcast to three or four days between posting during

later influence monetization and influence rewards stages. There are visual gaps from 2020 to 2021 that directly correlate to the departure of the other CHD co-host, Sofia Franklyn, during a contract dispute with the podcast's media company at the time, Barstool Sports. That month, Cooper signed a $60 million three-year contract with Spotify to solidify the podcast's production operation. By the end of July 2021, posting cadence had stabilized again.

YouTube Performance

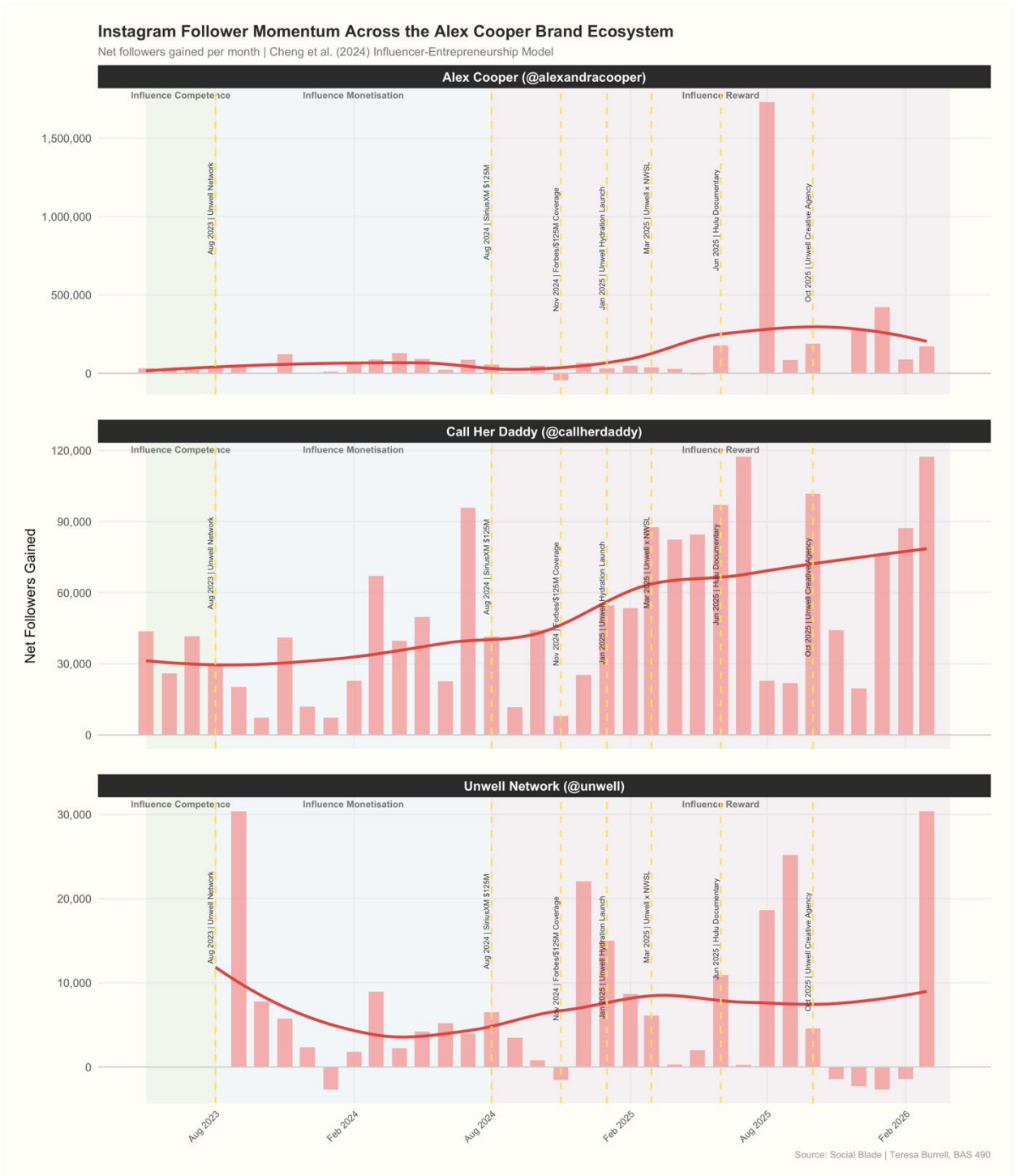
382 videos were retrieved via YouTube Data API v3. After deduplicating YouTube Shorts and reuploading content, the number of videos processed decreased to 340 unique video podcasts. Since the Spotify exclusivity contract went into effect, there is an obvious gap in data between 2021 and 2023. The volume of videos uploaded increased dramatically late 2023 and onward, with 73 videos in 2023, 92 in 2024, and 132 in 2025. During which, Alex Cooper and the CHD universe began to expand into the influence monetization and influence reward stage. Engagement rate, in this context, likes plus comments as a percentage of views, showed elevated activity during career milestones.

Instagram Metrics

Instagram platform data covers May 2023 to March 2026. Unwell, the most recent social media account created in the Cooper brand ecosystem was a great starting point to visualize Cooper’s brand during the last two stages of the IE model. The metrics of Unwell, CHD, and Alex Cooper’s personal Instagram account would be compared to each other. Within this almost three-year span, the CHD account grew from 1.9 million to 3.7 million in following. Outpacing this growth rate, Cooper’s personal account grew from 2.4 million to 6.6 million. Notable spikes in following can be seen after her Vogue wedding feature (April 2024), Forbes cover and SiriusXM deal (November 2024), the launch of Unwell Hydration at Target (January 2025),

second Vogue feature (August 2025), and the launch of Unwell Creative Agency (March 2026). Finally, the Unwell Network account grew from 280,000 to 566,000. February 2025 to June 2025 experienced a significant decrease in net followers after the shocking exit of the networks first big sign, Alix Earle in February of that same year.

Figure 3. *Instagram Follower Momentum Across Alex Cooper Brand Ecosystem*



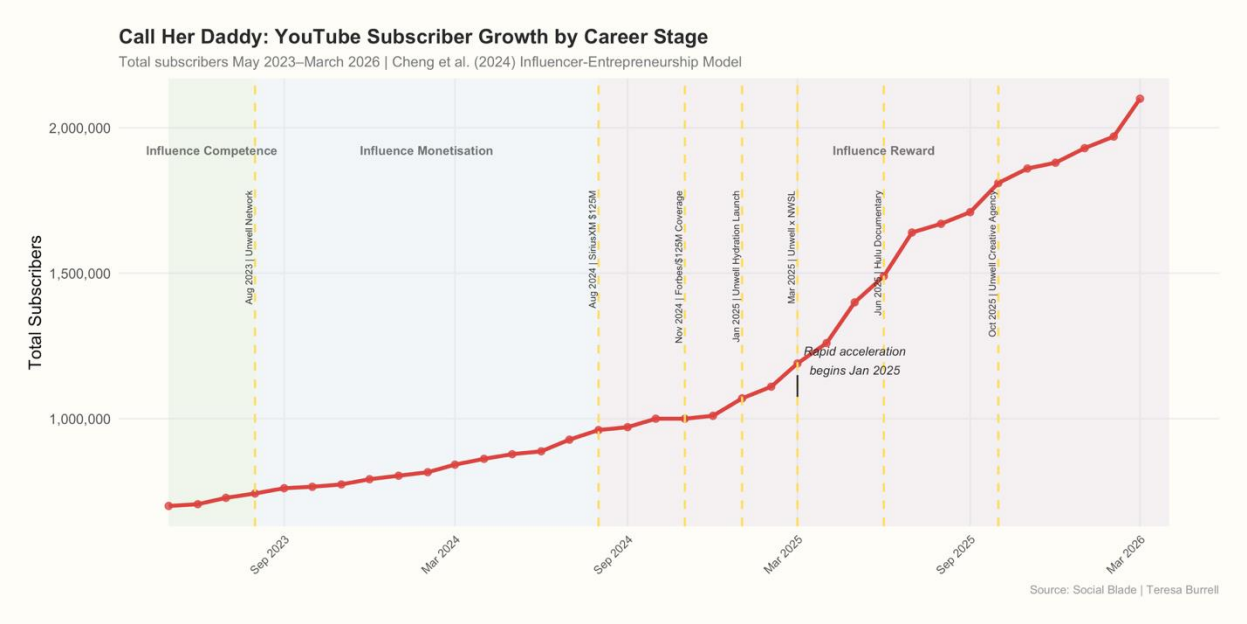
Note. Spotify release cadence (Panel 1), average monthly YouTube views per video (Panel 2), and YouTube audience engagement rate (Panel 3) mapped to the five stages of the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model (Cheng, Regt, & Young, 2024).

Release cadence data retrieved via the Spotify Web API. YouTube data retrieved via the YouTube Data API v3. Views in Panel 2 are capped at the 95th percentile for readability; the uncapped dataset is available in the raw data file. The shaded green region in Panels 2 and 3 denotes the Spotify exclusivity period (June 2021–August 2023) during which full episodes were not distributed on YouTube. Career stage boundaries reflect key business milestones in Cooper's trajectory. Data covers October 2018 through March 2026.

YouTube Social Blade

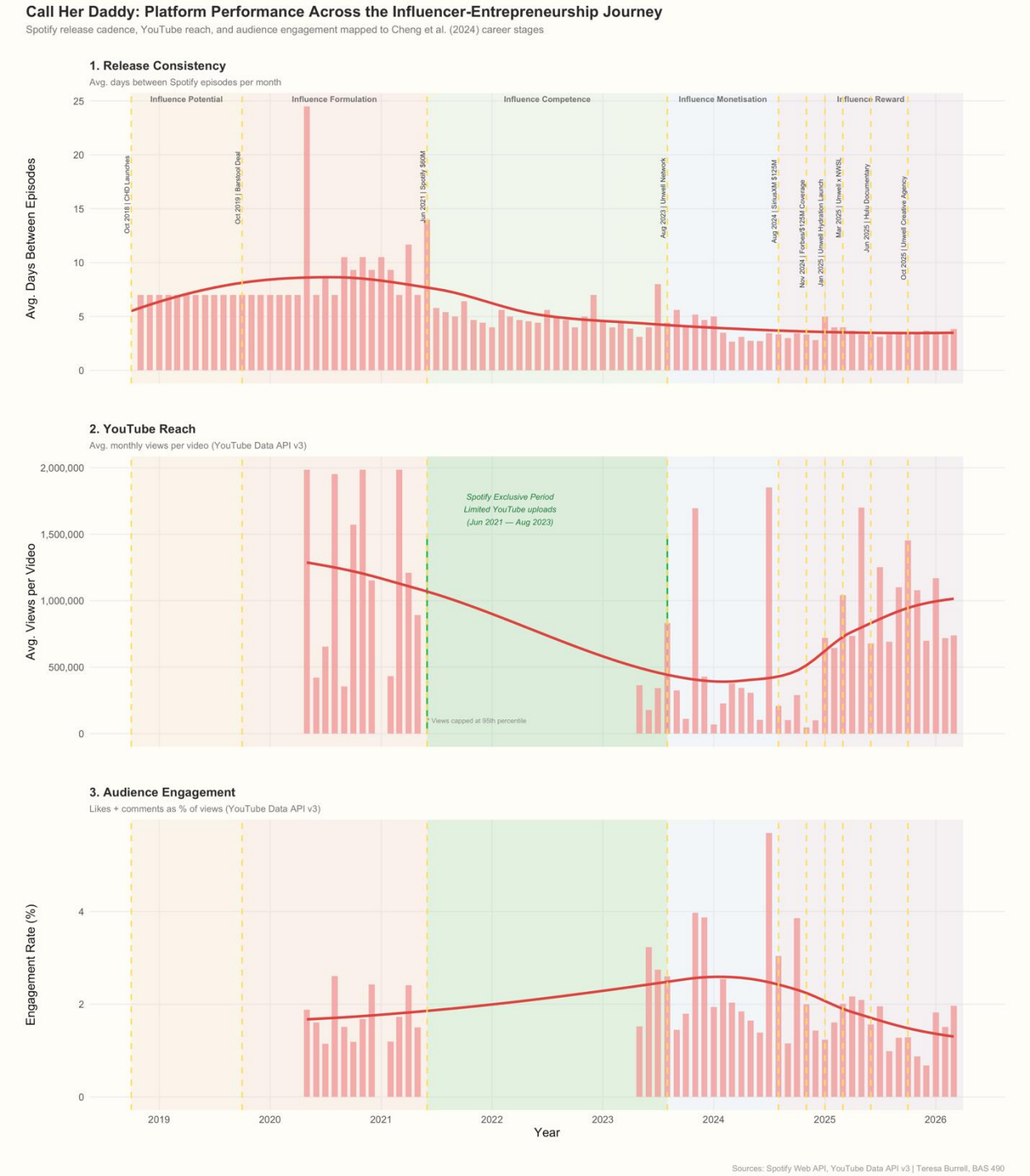
The CHD YouTube channel grew exponentially from May 2023 to 2.1 million in March 2026, catapulting Cooper from the influence monetization to influencer reward with a net gain of 1,417,000 subscribers. Total video podcast views rose from 79,668,025 in the competence stage to 576,838,285 in the monetization stage to 3,019,772,414 in the reward stage; mirroring an approximate increase by a factor of 38. The one consistent observation would be the monthly average of uploads, posted at 8.33, 9.33, and 9.15 videos per month, respectively. The subscriber growth from May 2023 to March 2026 was 700,000 to 2.1 million. It is evident that post January 2025 and onward, monthly follower gains increase incrementally 60,000, 80,000, 140,000, and 150,000.

Figure 4. *YouTube Subscriber Growth by Career Stage*



Note. Total YouTube subscribers for the Call Her Daddy channel (@callherdaddy) from May 2023 through March 2026, mapped to the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model stages (Cheng, Regt, & Young, 2024). Data sourced from Social Blade, which reports net monthly subscriber change rather than gross gained and lost figures; this is noted as a methodological limitation. Career stage boundaries reflect key business milestones in Cooper's trajectory. The annotation indicates the point of accelerated subscriber growth beginning January 2025, coinciding with the launch of Unwell Hydration at Target stores and increased mainstream media coverage following the August 2024 SiriusXM deal announcement.

Figure 5. *Platform Performance Across the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Journey*

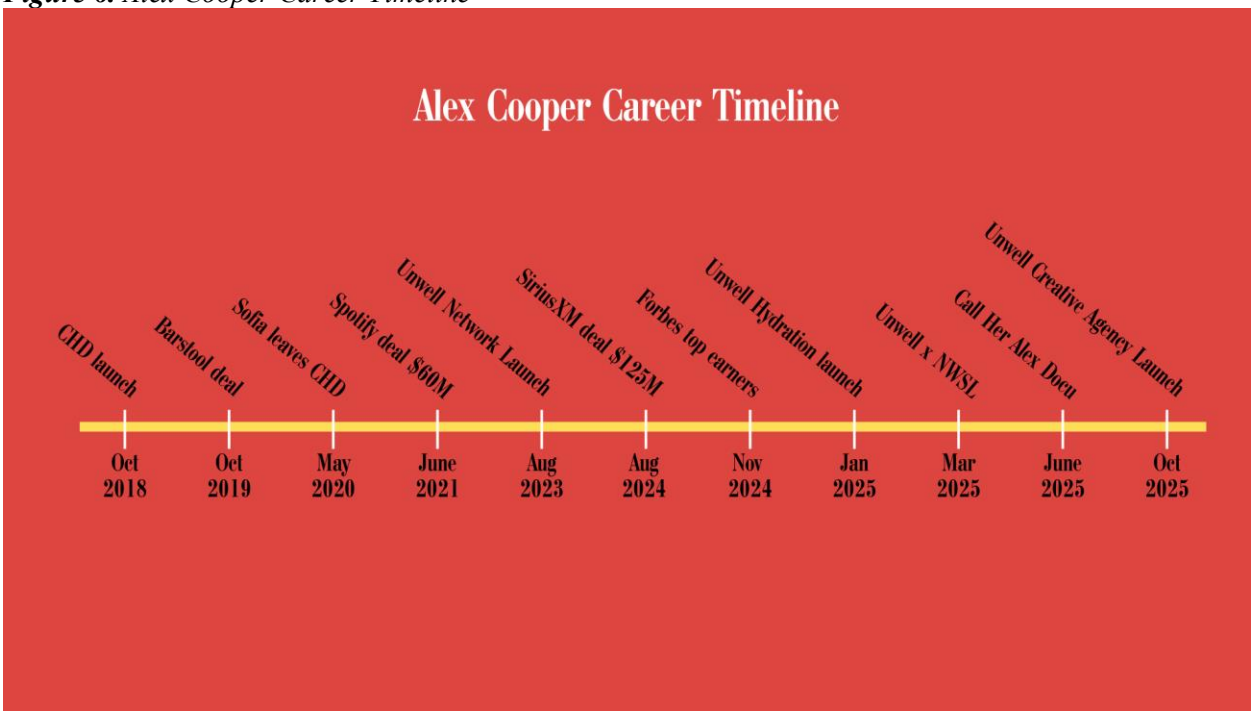


Note. Spotify release cadence (Panel 1), average monthly YouTube views per video (Panel 2), and YouTube audience engagement rate (Panel 3) mapped to the five stages of the Influencer-Entrepreneurship Model (Cheng et al., 2024). Release cadence data retrieved via the Spotify Web API. YouTube data retrieved via the YouTube Data API v3. Views in Panel 2 are capped at the 95th percentile for readability; the uncapped dataset is available in the raw data file. The shaded green region in

Panels 2 and 3 denotes the Spotify exclusivity period (June 2021–August 2023) during which full episodes were not distributed on YouTube. Career stage boundaries reflect key business milestones in Cooper's trajectory. Data covers October 2018 through March 2026.

Discussion

Figure 6. *Alex Cooper Career Timeline*



Note. Own Illustration

Key results in this study stimulate the question that structured this research: How is social media influencing changing branding from a transactional process into an entrepreneurial practice? This study examines the career trajectory of a media mogul from the influencer potential stage to influence reward stage using branding and content creation strategically to drive user engagement. As digital advertising rapidly changes the landscape of advertising, it is imperative that frameworks of traditional advertising converge with influencer marketing strategy to take advantage of the new economy of influencer entrepreneurship. Traditional brand touch points are defined as brand communications like physical stores, brand communications like paid media, owned media, and earned media. Now the transactional process that advertisers

are used to implementing no longer meets pre-defined brand outcomes. Fink states that "influencer branding can take all three forms of digital brand communications" (2021). Early career values like embedding quality content to facilitate trustworthiness to build community, aiming for high congruence with brand partnerships, creative innovation and consistent upload schedules, strategic alliance for capital acquisition promotes overall brand sustainability and reduce risk of over commercialization.

Early Career

Fink argued that source credibility (trustworthiness, expertise, and attractiveness), and informative and entertaining content, as well as strategic brand placement strategy, enhance the content that connects brand, consumer, and the influencer. Cooper's journey from Call Her Daddy to media mogul is the product of her podcast leveraging the trust her audience had in her to create entertaining, vulnerable, and honest video podcasts from the influence potential stage to the influence competence stage (See Figure 4). Concurrent to community brand building is the brand placement via Barstool and Spotify. Fink's connection between social media influencer (SMI), brand fit, and brand placement set up the next step of Call Her Daddy's capital acquisition. Cooper proved Call Her Daddy had a distinct competitive advantage with Barstool; proving to Spotify that the podcast was worth the extra production value. Spotify branding and ad breaks reinforced a new, elevated identity to CHD. Unlocking a more expensive level of brand presence to listeners (See Figure 5, influence formulation). Spotify welcomed Cooper in an era she could reflect "growing value and brand maturity" (Cheng, et al 2024) with just under 1 million monthly views on YouTube. Additionally, her proximity to Spotify resonated as "[Cooper's] highly relevant characteristics...consistent with highly relevant attributes of the brand [Spotify] (Fink, 2021). After the three-year Spotify deal and the subsequent launch of

Unwell, it indicated to her brand community she is worth the money to go out on her own. Users welcomed the Unwell Instagram account with upwards to 30,000 followers at launch. When high authenticity and trustworthiness are reached, brand communicators like Cooper gain enough momentum to propel beyond being the digital touch point of a third-party to become their own (See Figure 3, influence competence).

As Cooper's brand ecosystem grew, Cooper's personal social media outpaced that of CHD's by approximately 85%. Supporting the social capital theory of influencers' ability to create an identity that intertwines with their online presence to curate a narrative "which continually links their personal worth to market value" (Cheng et al. 2024). Cooper's personal account generated more social capital than CHD and Unwell at the reward stage (See Figure 3) indicating her brand could outgrow the podcast and solidify her digital celebrity.

Career Sustainability

Cheng, Regt, & Young suggest that influencer-entrepreneurs increasingly improve operational standards as they progress. CHD's tightening of episode release dates after June 2021 displayed better resources and budget (exclusivity contract with Spotify) for the podcast to get past the influencer competence stage (See Figure 4). The posting schedule during the influence potential stage was inconsistent; some videos uploaded a week apart from each other. By the influencer reward stage, full length podcast videos were uploaded two to three times a week with no more than three or four days in between. The $60 million exclusivity contract with Spotify became one of the biggest turning points for the Cooper brand ecosystem.

After the launch of the Unwell network in August 2023, the viral spikes in engagement metrics can be directly correlated to mainstream media placement and not content volume-

Cooper's second Vogue feature accounted for 1.7 million new followers in September 2025, January 2025's spike was due to press coverage of Unwell Hydration launch at Target despite its one month promotion (See Figure 3). Furthermore, leaning towards press reporting on the expansion of the Unwell network was strategic and complements Hudders, De Jans, & De Veirman (2021) warning about the over commercialization of branding- the biggest obstacle towards influence reward. However, by way of Fink's argument, it could suggest that user engagement bounced back because Cooper and the Unwell team could count on an already established fluid brand identity and brand image. The multiple media channels Cooper created represent "an important enabler of the establishment of an offline relationship" (Fink, 2021). Cheng et al. adds that over commercialization, often through capital acquisition, can moreover, prioritize top-line growth over bottom-line sustainability, risking the neglect of fundamental business principles (2024); Cooper's personal Instagram growth is an indication top-line growth of the Cooper celebrity brand concurrent with the growth of the Call Her Daddy reach (See Figure 4).

However, as Cooper's consortia moves towards mainstream advertising in the influence reward stage, Cooper and Unwell's authenticity remains. While Cooper briefly lost 45,512 followers directly after her Forbes cover and $125 million SiriusXM deal back in November 2024, presumably because of audience skepticism as she grew past the influence monetization phase, she quickly bounced back given the amount of publicity from mainstream media reports. As Unwell got bigger, Cheng et al.'s (2024) connection to the social capital theory remained just as, if not more important at the departure of Alix Earle. Earle had signed to become Unwell's first talent back in August 2023. A months-long follower exodus that could have only recovered

because Cooper's, as the individual, social capital outweighed the social capital of Unwell as an enterprise.

Conclusion

While the IE model can be seen as a progressive process, the data presents a different reality. As content and the influencer guide their career through each stage, concepts presented within each framework (content, influencing, branding, marketing, and the IE model) highlight a continuous shift within a spectrum of dynamic change. As digital creators begin their journey to entrepreneurship, two main hurdles become present- the goal of capital acquisition to bolster ventures from influence competence to influence monetization, and the risk of over commercialization once capital acquisition is achieved. Fink proves quality content builds community and earns audience trust, which are fundamental building blocks to branding. In addition, advocating for brand partnerships that have a high-fit congruence can also be seen as an expertise push from brand and influencer to audience. Lastly, the influencer entrepreneurship journey endorses creative innovation and upload consistency. These guidelines against Cooper's enterprise study showcase when these facets are solidified early-on; branding can build tolerance against over commercialization.

Converging the Influencer-Entrepreneurship model with guiding frameworks for drivers of use engagement offer an evidence-based guide for marketers, influencer relation strategists, aspiring influencers, and brand managers. Influencer marketing must interweave traditional advertising strategy to meet the demands of a new digital economy- influencer entrepreneurship.

Future Research Questions

What facets of social media platform algorithms use to gauge the amount of money user generated content creators get paid?

How can marketers and brand communicators mitigate the gap between passive and consuming engagement on social media platforms?

How are influencer brands perceived within the fit-construct and how does that influence overall brand success?

What is the connection between marketing and branding in the context of the existing frameworks in social media marketing research?

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